

A Comparison of Ancient Civilizations

Egypt, Greece, Rome

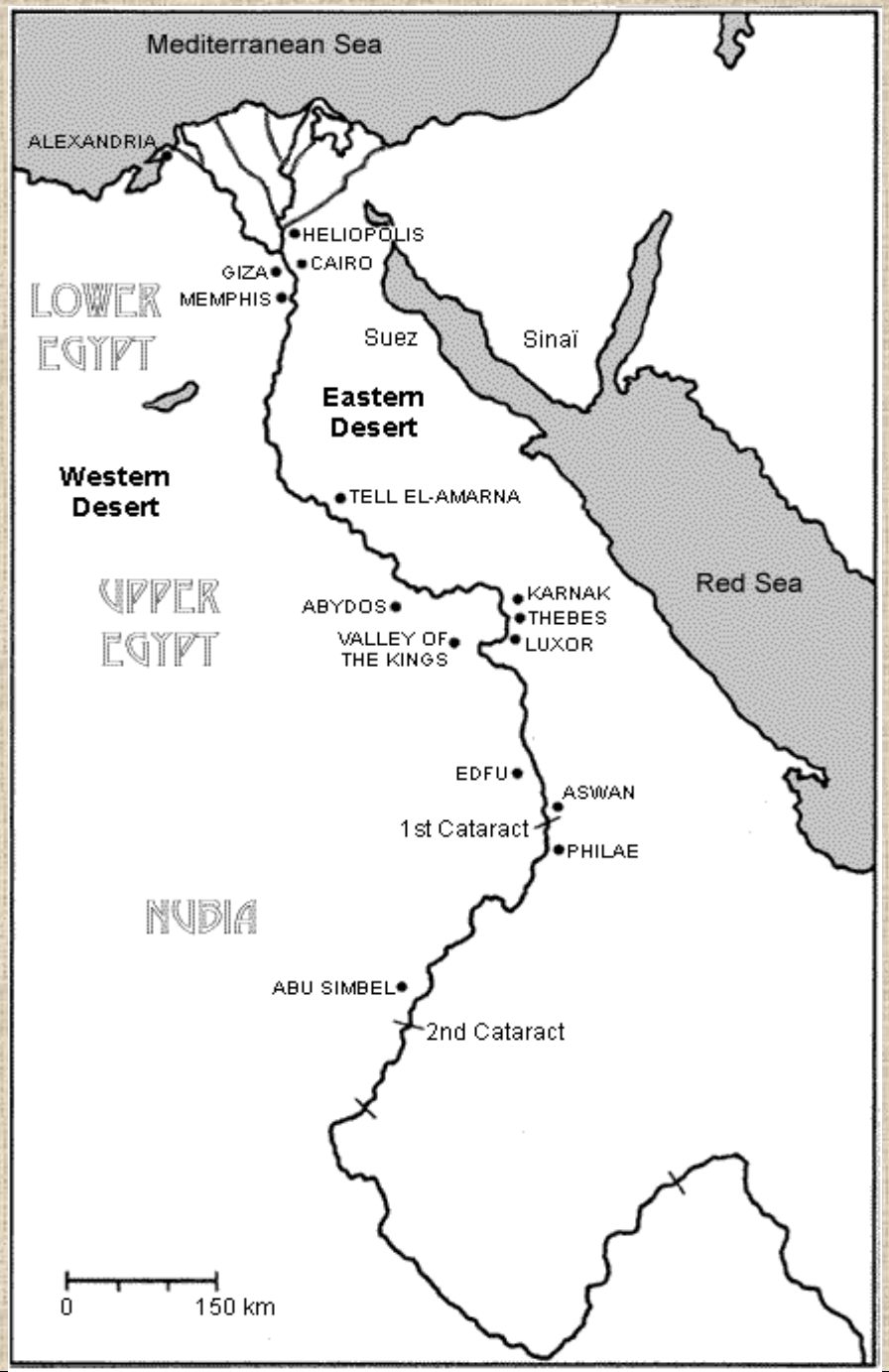
ARCH 305 Architecture and Town Planning


Geographical
Influences



The **NILE RIVER** , the longest river in the world (**6,650 kilometers or 4,132 miles)**, flows north from the ***heart of Africa to the Mediterranean*** Sea. Its flood plain was a **magnet for life** -- human, plant and animal. Humans were drawn there because they could grow crops and settle into permanent villages.

EGYPT



Bounded on the south, east and west by an impassable desert, and on the north by the sea

ANCIENT EGYPT was protected from outside influences, which allowed it to evolve in its own unique way.

EGYPT



For centuries, **THE NILE RIVER FLOODED THE VALLEY**, enriching the land with a thick layer of alluvial soil. Flooding occurred from **July to September** as the result of tropical rains. The river attained its highest level in October, then began to recede to its lowest point sometime between April and June.



TRANSPORTATION: The Nile River was the highway that joined the country together. Up until the nineteenth century, travel by land was virtually unknown.

GREECE



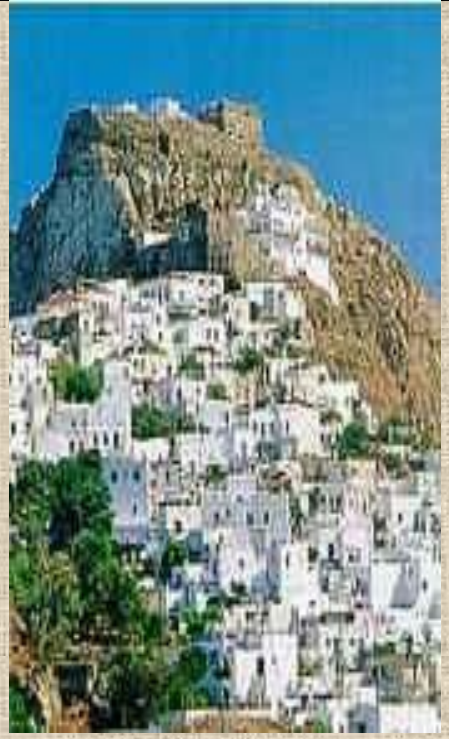
Located in **southeastern Europe**, Greece is defined by a series of mountains and surrounded on all sides except the **north by water**.

GREECE



- The **Mediterranean Sea moderates Greece's climate**, cooling the air in summer and providing warmth in the winter months.
- Summers are generally hot and dry. Winters are moderate and rainy in coastal regions and cold and snowy in mountainous areas.

GREECE





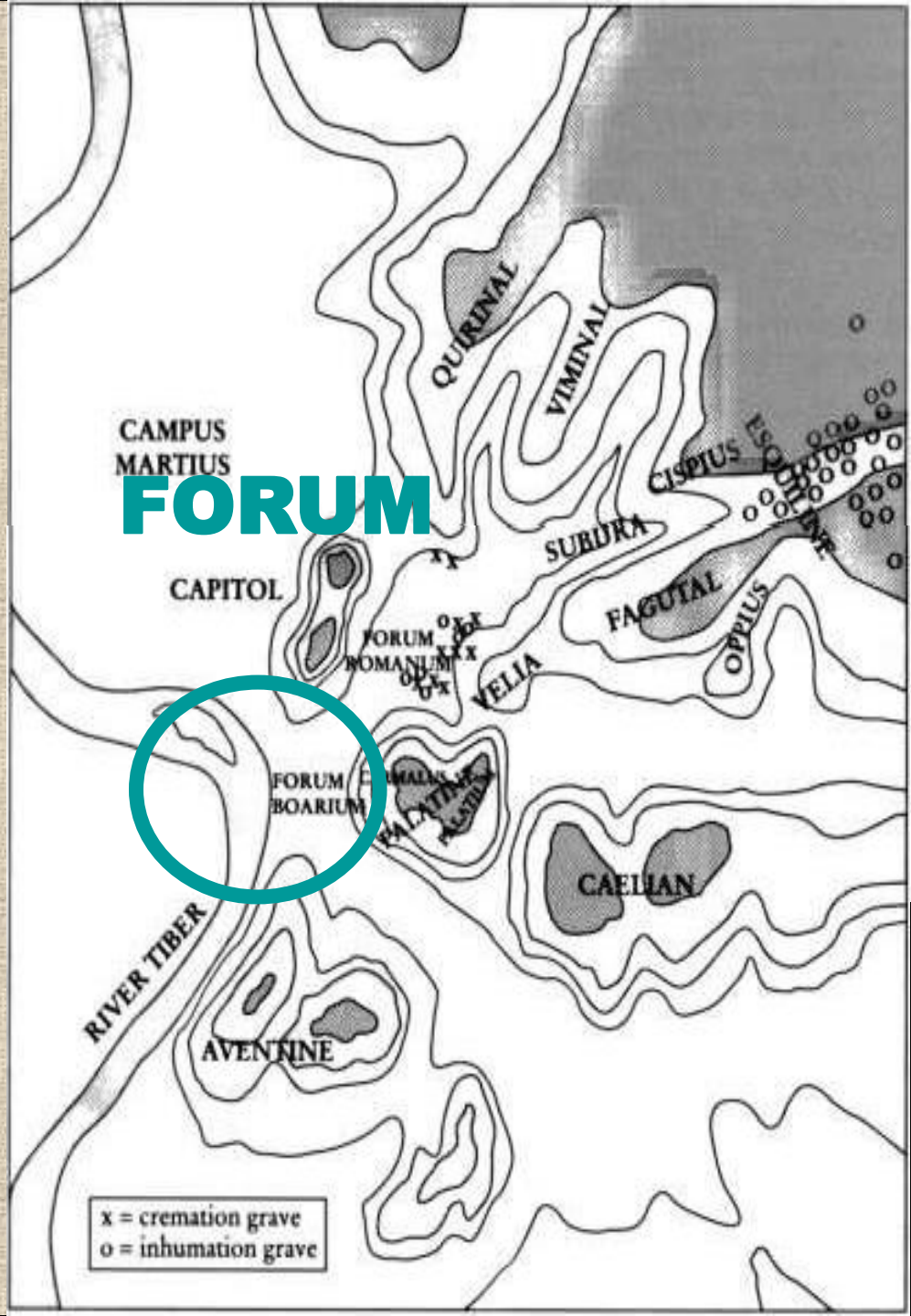


- Numerous **MOUNTAIN RANGES**, which crisscross the peninsula, hampered internal communications and led to the development of independent city-states.
- Numerous **ISLANDS** and the indented coastlines of the Greek peninsula and of Asia Minor stimulated a seagoing trade.
- The **ROCKY SOIL** and limited natural resources encouraged the Greeks to establish colonies abroad.

ROME

- Forum: A meeting Place

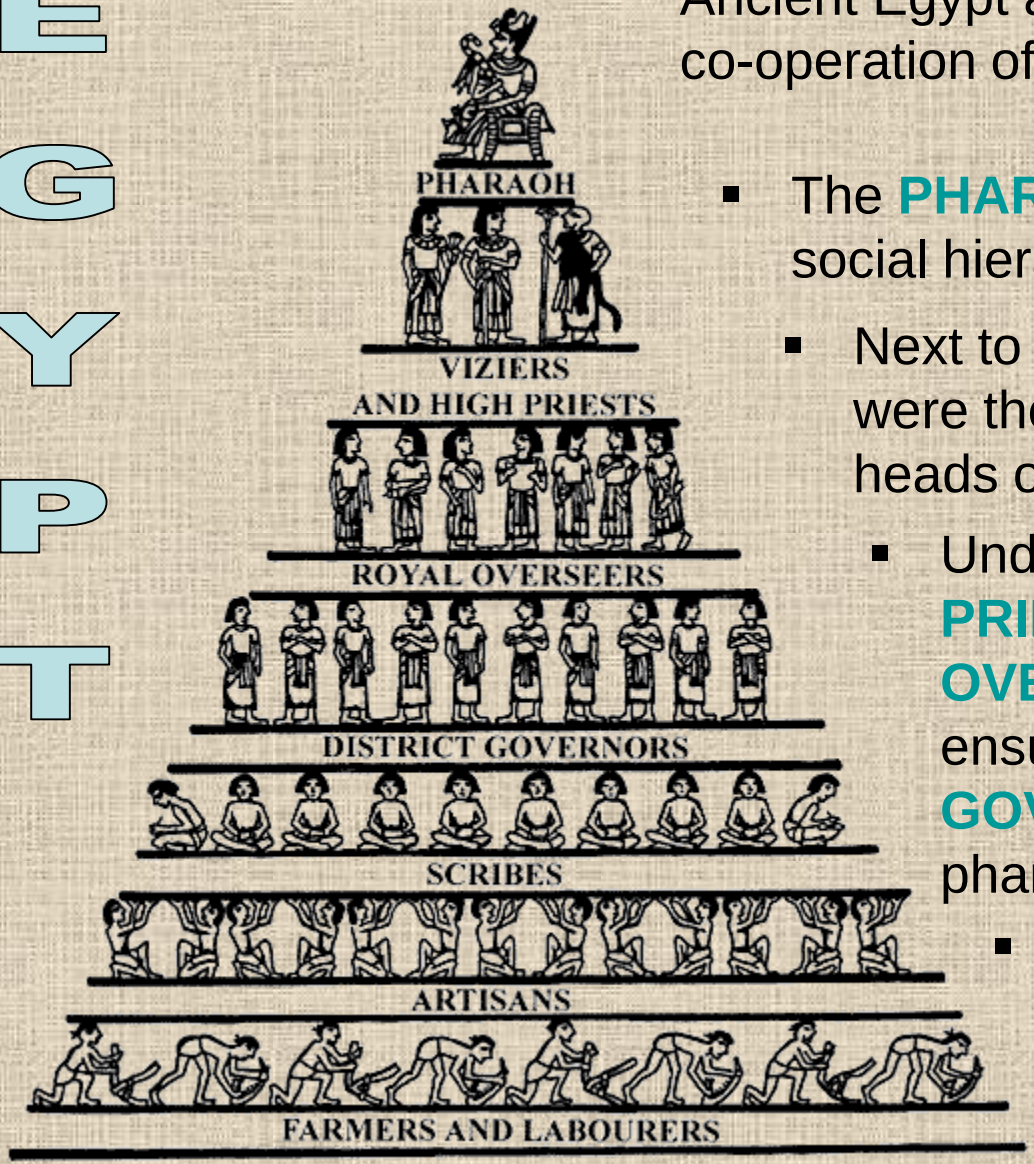
- Modern scholars believe that in the 8th century B.C., the inhabitants of some small Latin settlements on hills in the **Tiber valley** united and established a common meeting place, the **FORUM, around which the city of Rome grew.**





Social and Political Structure

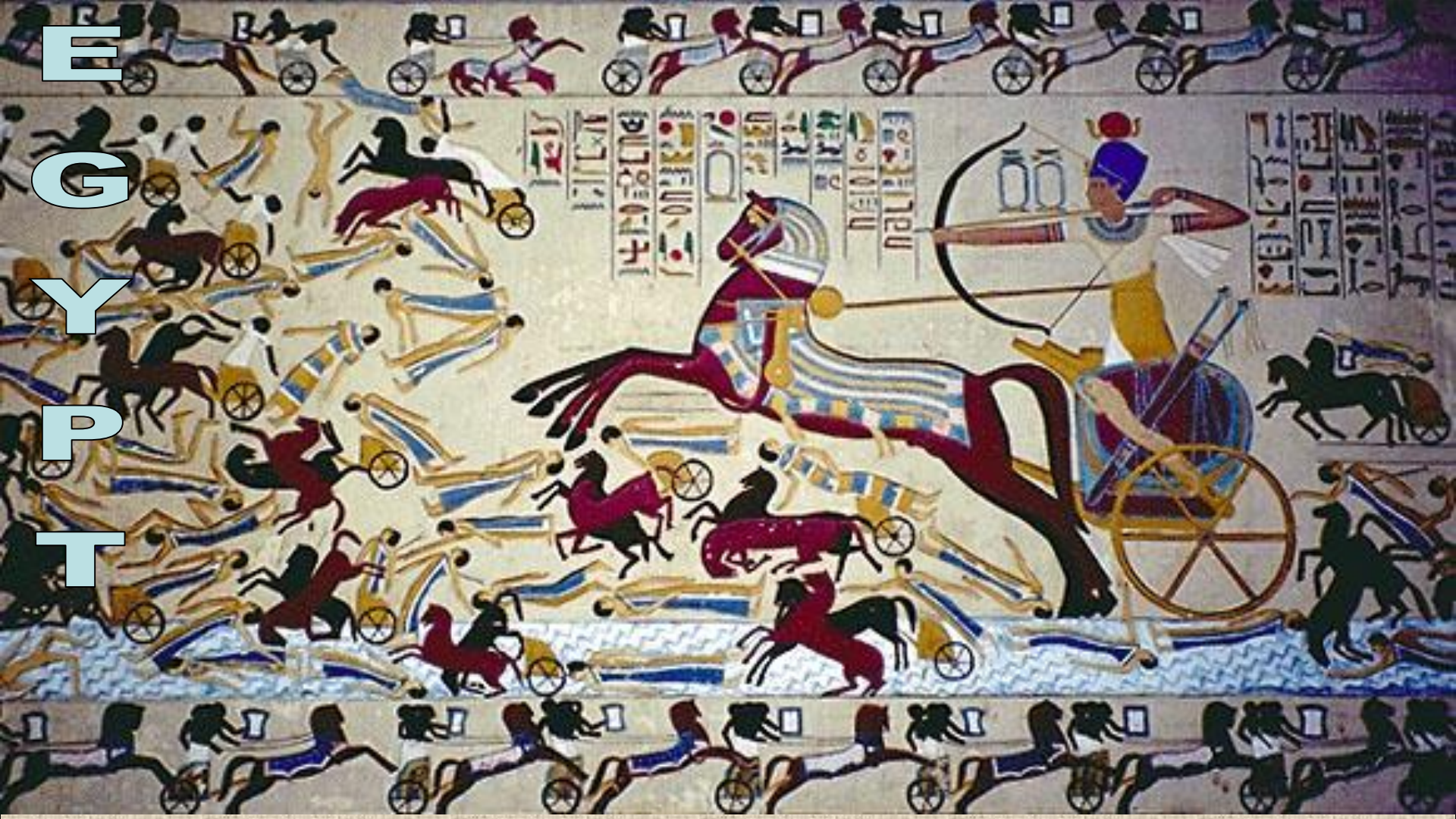
EGYPT



Ancient Egypt achieved stability through the co-operation of all levels of the population.

- The **PHAROAH** was at the top of the social hierarchy.
  - Next to him, the most powerful officers were the **VIZIERS**, the executive heads of the bureaucracy.
    - Under them were the **HIGH PRIESTS**, followed by **ROYAL OVERSEERS** (administrators) who ensured that the 42 **DISTRICT GOVERNORS** carried out the pharaoh's orders.
      - At the bottom of the hierarchy were the **SCRIBES, ARTISANS, FARMERS**, and **LABORERS**.

EGYPT



To reinforce their image as powerful divine rulers, the **PHARAOHS** represented themselves in writings and sculptured reliefs on temple walls. They often **DEPICTED THEMSELVES AS WARRIORS** who single-handedly killed scores of enemies and slaughtered a whole pride of lions.

GREECE



The **POLIS** (city-state) consisted of a city and its surrounding plains and valleys. The nucleus of the *polis* was the elevated, fortified site called the **ACROPOLIS** where people could take refuge from attack. With the revival of commerce, a **TRADING CENTER** developed below the acropolis.

GREECE



Four major **TYPES OF GOVERNMENT** evolved in ancient Greece:

- **Monarchy** (rule of a king) limited by an aristocratic council and a popular assembly.
- **Oligarchy** (rule of the few) arising when the aristocratic council ousted the king and abolished the assembly.
- **Tyranny** (rule by one who ruled without legal authority) riding to power on the discontent of the lower classes.
- **Democracy** (rule of the people), the outstanding political achievement of the Greeks.

GREECE

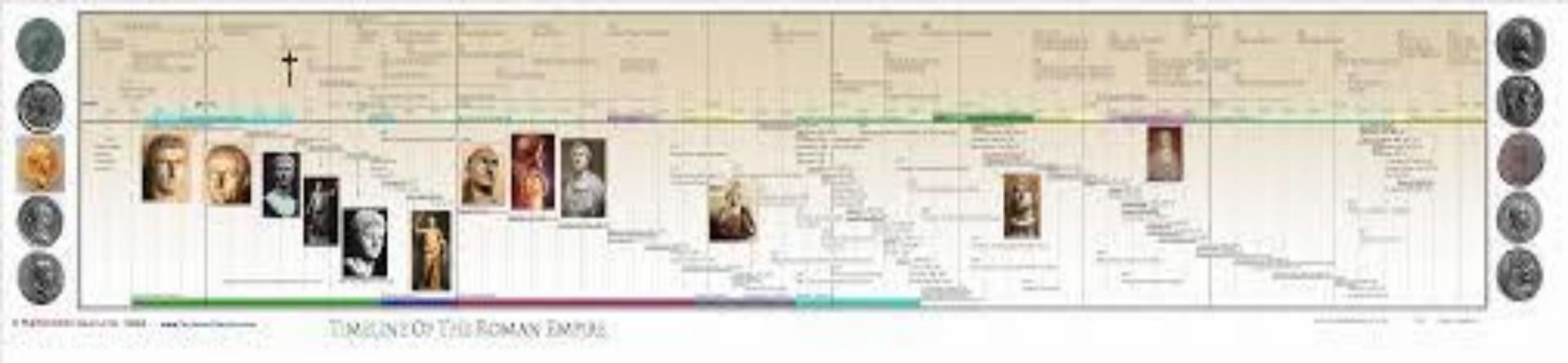
ATHENIAN DEMOCRACY

- **DIRECT PARTICIPATION** was the key to Athenian **DEMOCRACY**. In the Assembly, every male citizen was not only entitled to attend as often as he pleased but also had the right to **DEBATE**, offer **AMENDMENTS**, and vote on **PROPOSALS**.
- Every man had a say in whether to declare **WAR** or stay in **PEACE**. Basically any thing that required a government decision, all male citizens were allowed to participate in.





WOMEN, SLAVES, and **RESIDENT ALIENS** were **DENIED CITIZENSHIP**



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THE ROMAN MONARCHY to 509 B.C.

According to tradition, early Rome was ruled by **KINGS** elected by the people.

- The king's executive power was conferred by a **POPULAR ASSEMBLY** made up of all arms-bearing citizens.
- The king turned for advice to a council of nobles, called the **SENATE**.
- Each senator had lifelong tenure and the members of this group and their families constituted the **PATRICIAN** class.
- The other class of Romans, the **PLEBEIANS** (commoners) included small farmers, artisans, and many clients (dependents of patrician landowners). In return for a livelihood, the clients gave their patrician patrons political support in the **ASSEMBLY**

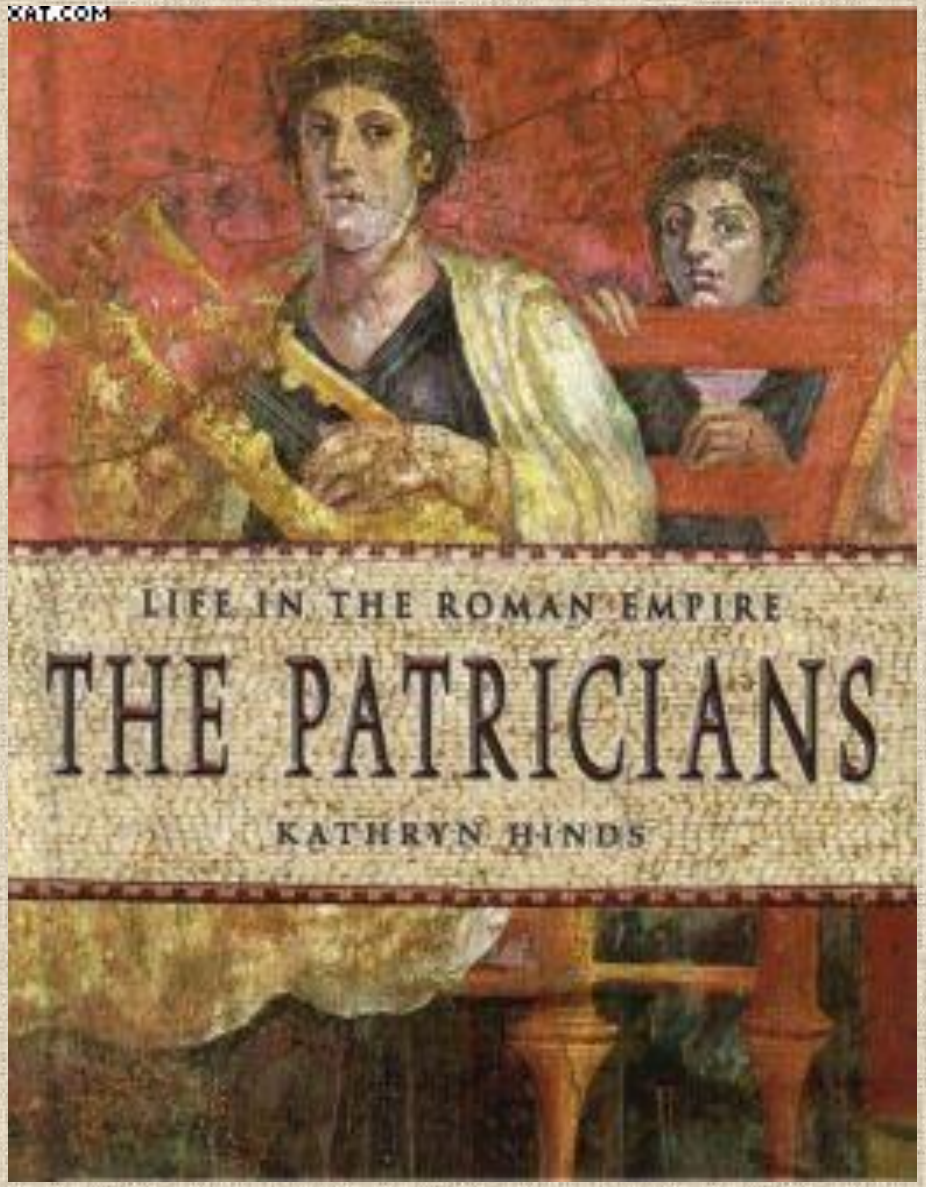


ROMAN SENATE

R O M E

EARLY REPUBLIC 509-133 B.C.

- In 509 B.C., according to tradition, the **PATRICIANS** expelled the last Etruscan king and established a **REPUBLIC**.
- The power to rule was transferred to two new officials called **CONSULS**.
- Elected annually from the patrician class, the consul exercised their power in the interests of that class.



R O M E

PLEBEIAN STRUGGLE FOR EQUAL RIGHTS

- For more than two centuries following the establishment of the Republic, the plebeians struggled for political and social equality.
  - Outright civil war was averted by the willingness of the patricians to compromise.
  - Much of the plebeians' success in this struggle was also due to their tactics of collective action and to their having organized a corporate group within the state.
  - The unofficial body was known as the **PLEBEIAN COUNCIL**.
  - It was presided over by plebeian officials called **TRIBUNES**, whose job was to safeguard the interests of the plebeians and to negotiate with the consuls and the Senate.



ROME



- The advancement of the **PLEBEIANS** during the early Republic took two main lines: the safeguarding of their **FUNDAMENTAL RIGHTS** and the progressive enlargement of their share of **POLITICAL POWER**.

R O M E

FUNDAMENTAL RIGHTS

- Because the consuls often interpreted Rome's unwritten customary law to suit **PATRICIAN INTERESTS**, the plebeians demanded that it be written down.
  - As a result, about 450 B.C., the law was inscribed on twelve tablets of bronze and set up publicly in the Forum.
  - **The LAW OF THE TWELVE TABLETS** was the first landmark in the long history of Roman law.



ROME

- The plebeians in time acquired other fundamental rights and safeguards:
  - They secured the right to **APPEAL A DEATH SENTENCE** imposed by a consul and to be retried before the popular assembly.
  - The tribunes gained a **VETO POWER** over any legislation or executive act that threatened the rights of the plebeians.
  - **MARRIAGE** between patricians and plebeians, prohibited by the Law of the Twelve Tablets, was legalized.
  - The enslavement of citizens for **DEBT** was abolished



R O M E

POLITICAL POWER

- Little by little, the plebeian class acquired more power in the functioning of government.
  - In 367 B.C., **ONE CONSULSHIP** was reserved for the plebeians.
  - Before the end of the century, they were eligible to hold other important positions: **PRAETOR** (in charge of the law courts), **QUAESTOR** (treasurer), **CENSOR** (supervisor of public morals and state contracts).

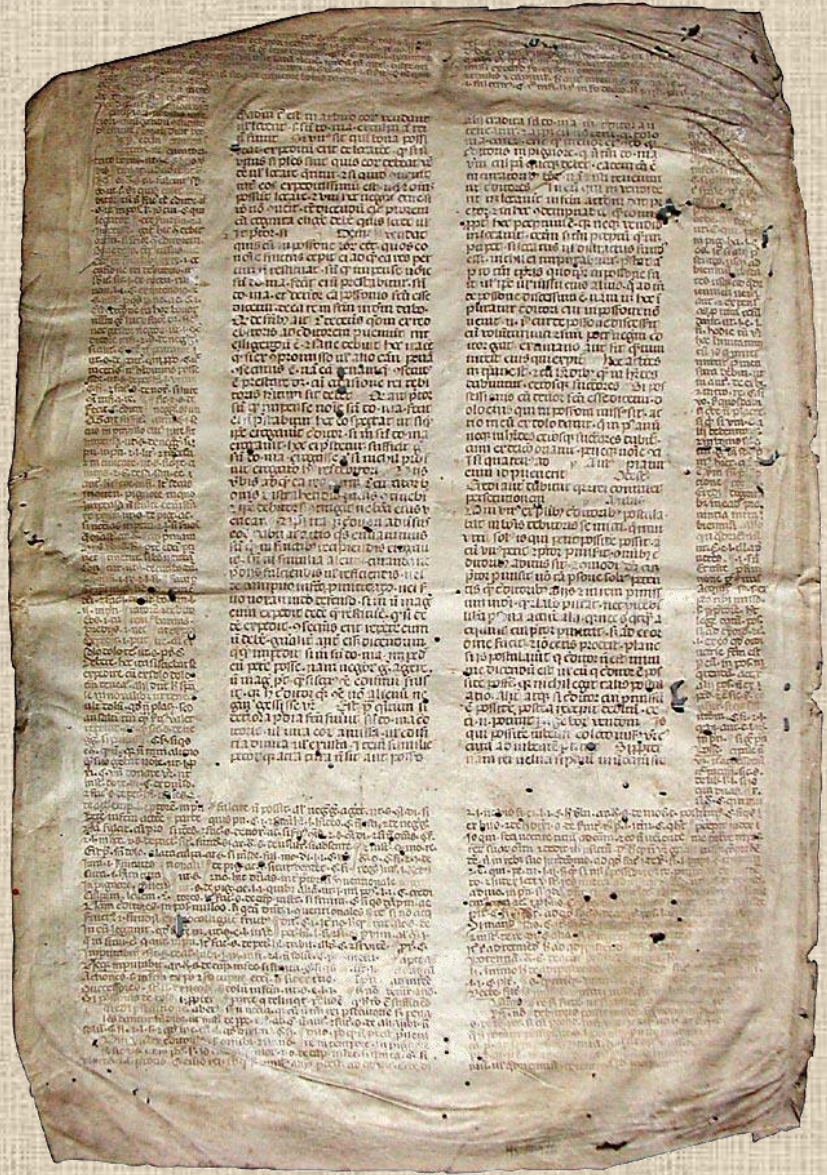


  - Some plebeians succeeded in gaining entry to the SENATE.
  - The long struggle for equality ended in 287 B.C. when the **PLEBEIAN COUNCIL** was recognized as a constitutional body, henceforth known as the **TRIBAL ASSEMBLY**, with the right to **PASS LAWS** that were binding on all citizens.
  - The Roman Republic was now technically a democracy, although in actual practice a senatorial aristocracy of patricians and rich plebeians continued to control the state.

R O M E

POLITICAL THEORY AND LEGAL PRINCIPLES

- Roman political thinkers contributed many governmental theories:
  - The **SOCIAL CONTRACT** theory (that government originated as a voluntary agreement among citizens).
  - The idea of **POPULAR SOVEREIGNTY** (that all power ultimately resides with the people).
  - The concept that **LAW** must be the basis for government.



MS 209/06
Digestum Vetus, Book 4:2, with the Accursian Gloss. Italy, 14th c.